prosecute the former head of state of the German Democratic Republic for actions he took while in office.' When asked if the political changes in Moscow had created pressure from the Russians for him to quit the country, Honecker snapped: 'There is no such pressure. On the contrary, we are being well treated so far, nothing has changed about that.' In fact, it wasn't long afterward that the Russians unsuccessfully tried to convince him to leave voluntarily. After endless to-ing and fro-ing during October and November, Russian Minister of Justice, Nikolai Fyodorov personally paid a visit to Honecker's dacha on 10 December with an extradition order declaring it must be enforced no later than 13 December 1991, otherwise, he would be 'delivered' to the FRG by force.30 It was a frosty encounter. With merciless candour, Margot revealed:31

We were informed that the internal situation in the Soviet Union had changed since the attempted putsch. The economic and political pressure of the FRG was growing in all fields. The Honecker issue was becoming a burden to relations between the Russian-German governments. A compromise had to be found. On the Soviet side, the best solution was for Erich Honecker to return voluntarily. Moscow said they would work hard to get him a decent deal.

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What most concerned Margot, however, was the consent of the Soviet Union to a 'voluntary return' of her husband, which she said was in essence a deportation and an 'immoral action' from an ally and friend. 'We demanded a lawyer,' Margot added, 'since according to international law, in such a case the person involved must be heard in a court proceeding. But such a demand was ignored.'

Just at the moment when it seemed that there were no stumbling blocks to returning Honecker to Berlin, an unexpected incident happened. On 11